

▷ BURYING HER EGGS

Females lay 5 to 10 eggs in summer and bury them in dry soil. The young, which are about 6 in (15 cm) long, hatch nine months later.

▽ BEADED BODY

Gila scales are rounded and slightly domed. The pattern of black with pink, red, or orange patches—unique on each individual—warns potential predators of its toxic bite.



- ↔ 16–24 in (41–61 cm)
- ⚖ 3–5 lb (1.4–2.3 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🦋 Eggs, small birds, mammals
- 🏠 🌱



SW. US,
N. Mexico



Desert blond tarantula

Aphonopelma chalcodes

Lacking good vision, this desert hunter is at great risk of predation during the day. For this reason it remains in its burrow and waits for night to fall. In the dark, touch is the tarantula's main link to its surroundings. It uses its feet and mouthparts to detect vibrations caused by passing animals that touch a network of silk threads radiating from the entrance of its burrow. The spider lies in wait for prey, then rushes out and kills it with a venomous bite.

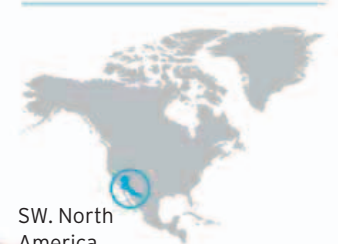
Mating quest

Tarantulas grow slowly, reaching sexual maturity at 10 years. Males then search for mates, delivering a silk sac of sperm to each female they find. The eggs are laid on a silk sheet at the sun-warmed mouth of the burrow. Spiderlings stay in the burrow for a few days only.

▽ HAIRY HUNTER

The tarantula's body hairs are sensory but also have a defensive function. When threatened, the spider uses its back legs to flick barbed, irritating hairs at its attacker.

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–7.6 cm)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🦋 Crickets, grasshoppers, small lizards
- 🏠 🌱



SW. North
America

